



The Great Pyramid of Khufu

The largest and oldest of the three Giza pyramids, this is what many people now think of as the greatest “true” pyramid ever. It probably took about 20 years to build, involving a workforce of thousands.



The Giza pyramid complex

The vast size of these royal tombs reflects the divine status of the 4th-dynasty kings. The most distant tomb is Khufu’s “Great” pyramid; in the center is Khafre’s; the smallest pyramid, in the foreground, is that of the pharaoh Menkaure.



Working the land

This fresco shows people harvesting wheat. The Egyptians created large areas for cultivation, using complex irrigation systems fed by the Nile.

It is said that most ordinary people in the Old Kingdom led miserable lives pressed into the pharaoh’s service, building vast constructions or growing crops to feed the cities, in return for just enough sustenance to stay alive. However, evidence suggests that there was an independent local life, too, including markets where people sold produce and simple crafts. The fact that anyone could, theoretically, gain high office also contradicts the idea of a total dictatorship.

The age of the pyramids

The Old Kingdom is best known for its advances in stone building techniques, which saw fruition in the famous “step pyramid” at Saqqara, (see Imhotep, left) and then in the colossal royal pyramid tombs of the

4th dynasty (c. 2613–2494 BCE). Built at Giza, close to Memphis at the edge of the desert, these are among the greatest building achievements in history. The Great Pyramid—the tomb of the pharaoh Khufu—was one of the



Mallet

Simple, short-shafted wooden mallets like this were used with chisels to cut stone slabs with great precision and to produce fine relief carvings.

Seven Wonders of the ancient world, and the only one that survives intact today. Just to the east of the pyramid lies the Great Sphinx, a massive part-lion, part-human statue, thought to have Khufu’s features. The Giza pyramids are one of the earliest examples of using quarried stone. Huge blocks of limestone were transported from some distance away, cut with incredible precision, and lifted into place to make a perfectly fitted construction. No one knows exactly how this was achieved. Each pyramid may have been surrounded by a sloping bank, built

upward as the pyramid grew higher. The stone blocks may have been moved up the slope manually by using rollers and levers.

2 MILLION The number of limestone blocks, each weighing 16 tons (15,000 kg), used to construct Khufu’s Great Pyramid at Giza.

A Middle Eastern power

Egypt became a major player in Middle Eastern politics during the Old Kingdom period. There is evidence of long-distance contact with many regions, including parts of modern Syria, Libya, Lebanon, and Sudan. Contact arose because Egypt wanted to keep its borders safe, and to trade for materials, such as wood. Borders cannot be maintained or crossed without negotiation, so Egypt must have started to develop the diplomatic skills for which it became famous.

AFTER

There are countless theories about the Old Kingdom collapse; but no one knows for certain what happened.

NOBLES AND NOMES

By the 6th dynasty (c. 2345–2181 BCE), the pharaohs **granted certain powers to nobles and governors** of the regional districts, or “**nomes**.” This may have gradually undermined the pharaoh’s authority. It is also suggested that as the pharaoh lost control, others were able to take more power for themselves.



PHARAOH PEPI II

THE OLD KINGDOM COLLAPSES

At the end of the 6th dynasty, especially after the reign of **Pepy II**, the Old Kingdom started to fade and Egypt moved into a more uncertain time called the First Intermediate Period **64–65 >>**. **Royal authority weakened** and Memphis lost some of its importance compared with other towns and cities.

WHY DID IT HAPPEN?

Links have been made with Egypt’s dependence on the Nile, saying that **extreme flooding, drought, or both brought great destruction or famine**. This would have been especially disastrous if central authority was weak. Threats to Egypt’s borders may also have been a factor in the Old Kingdom’s decline.